When advertising becomes a promise

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A casebook of durable growth runaway expectations and humane repair

Prepared for Blackwish · 23 October 2026

This is a companion to *Advertising research for audience benefit and sustainable distribution*. It adds historical stories and deeper mechanisms; it does not replace, ratify or deploy the earlier report. The purpose is to understand how useful promotion develops into a durable asset, and how an attractive offer can create obligations its maker cannot fulfill.

The central question is not simply whether an advertisement was persuasive. It is: **What did people come to expect, what could they actually obtain, and who kept paying the cost of making the promise true?** Each story follows the promise, its distribution, the work needed to deliver it, the observed result and the limits of the evidence.

The vehicles differ. A tire guide is owned editorial media. A prize offer is a sales promotion. A restaurant star is earned recognition. A game launch combines publicity with a product release. A fan-development platform is partly product operations. Calling all of these “advertising” without distinction would conceal the very mechanisms worth studying.

The cases are selected histories, not a representative sample or an estimated success rate. Corporate accounts substantiate financial outcomes without isolating campaign causality. Company participation counts remain company reports. Court allegations, settlements, judgments and guilty pleas retain their different meanings. None of the histories supplies a Blackwish sales forecast, legal clearance or certification.

Part I Durable growth supported by operations

1 Michelin the advertisement became a service

Vehicle: owned utility and editorial media; later, a substantial institution of evaluation.

A useful place to begin is not with a slogan but with a journey. Michelin's institutional history describes a guide that helped motorists find their way, repair a vehicle, obtain fuel, eat and sleep. The commercial idea was to make motoring easier and encourage the activity in which tires were consumed. After its free-distribution period, the guide became paid in 1920, with paid advertising removed. Restaurant stars began in 1926; the three-star hierarchy followed in 1931. These are company historical accounts, not a measured experiment in tire demand. [1]

The guide's distinctive advantage was that it could be worth keeping even when the reader had no immediate reason to buy tires. Its name remained near a relevant activity rather than appearing only at the transaction. The plausible mechanism is complementary demand: improve the usefulness or attractiveness of an activity, and a product used in that activity may benefit. That is a mechanism to investigate, not an established guide-to-tire conversion rate.

Over time, the promise changed. Practical travel information became influential judgment about where a journey was worth making. Michelin describes professional inspectors, anonymous visits, payment of restaurant bills and collective star decisions. Those safeguards require continuing

editorial labor. They are the company's stated process, not an independent audit of every inspection. A trusted guide cannot renew its promise merely by republishing last year's design. [3]

The institution also changed its distribution. In October 2025 Michelin reported nearly 70 destinations, seven million social subscribers and 3.5 million active app users, alongside digital selections and booking services. This is evidence of a surviving, adapting media/service asset. It does not tell us whether the guide alone is profitable or how many incremental tires it sells. Longevity answers “did it endure?” rather than “was every investment efficient?” [2]

A service built around judgment acquires a second obligation: explain how its coverage is funded. Visit California's 2019 program described a partnership supplying restaurant reviews, articles, photography and video. Contemporary reporting identified a $600,000 one-year tourism-board investment and reported Michelin's claim of editorial independence. Payment to extend geographic coverage is different from payment for an individual rating; the latter is not established here. An evaluator can control its verdicts while commercial arrangements influence which places receive attention. Readers need both distinctions. [4] [5]

There is also a consequence for the people evaluated. A mixed-method study followed 276 elite New York restaurants, including 92 that received stars, and found star receipt associated with later exit risk. Interviews described changed expectations and bargaining pressures. This is observational evidence about earned recognition in a particular restaurant market - not evidence that buying advertisements causes closures, and not proof that a closure is a bankruptcy. [6]

The deeper lesson. A promotional object can become valuable enough to have a life beyond its original sales purpose. That is an achievement and a maintenance commitment. For a small creative project, the transferable question is not “Can we make a famous guide?” It is “What complete, useful object would someone reasonably keep even if they never adopted our product?” The answer still needs a credible connection to the project, an update owner and an affordable scope. A generic magazine with a logo is not automatically the same mechanism.

2 LEGO the turnaround came before the celebrated content story

Vehicle: a product system, retail relationships, community participation and entertainment working together.

LEGO's financial recovery is real, but its chronology resists a simple story about a movie or a fan community saving the business. The 2004 annual report recorded a DKK 1.931 billion net loss. It also showed a positive result before special items, finance and tax; restructuring and impairment affected the bottom line. “A severe reported loss” and “some underlying improvement” were therefore compatible descriptions of the same year. [7]

In 2005 revenue reached DKK 7.050 billion and net profit DKK 505 million, including DKK 331 million from continuing activities. Management described work on retailer profitability, inventory turnover, costs, core products and the disposal of non-core activities. Prior revenue was restated after retailer contributions were reclassified, so an unadjusted before-and-after revenue chart would mislead. The recovery involved making an operating system work better, not simply making the brand look more exciting. [8]

The later entertainment success sat on top of that recovery. In 2014 LEGO reported DKK 28.578 billion revenue and DKK 9.697 billion operating profit. Management identified movie-related products as a significant contributor, alongside several established product lines and geographic expansion. The accounts demonstrate a large successful business; they do not separate the movie's advertising effect from its merchandise, licensing, distribution or the strength of other ranges. [9]

The community chronology is equally important. The Japanese CUUSOO initiative began in 2008, expanded globally in 2011 and became LEGO Ideas in 2014. It cannot explain the initial return to profit in 2005. At its tenth anniversary, LEGO reported more than a million platform members, over 26,000 submitted ideas and 23 released sets. That is evidence of a functioning participation and product-development channel, not a measured share of consolidated profit. [10] [11]

A small rule carries a large operational lesson: reaching 10,000 supporters earns an idea a review, not guaranteed manufacture. Popularity is an input to a decision, not a substitute for licensing, engineering or portfolio feasibility. The audience is offered a real path without being promised that every popular proposal must become a product. The credibility of participation depends on making that distinction intelligible before people invest their work. [12]

Success did not abolish complexity. In 2017 LEGO said the organization built for rapid growth was itself making growth harder and announced a simpler structure with approximately 1,400 expected job reductions. Full-year revenue subsequently fell 8%, while consumer sales were flat; inventory cleanup contributed to the revenue decline. Selling fewer units into the retail channel was not equivalent to an 8% fall in purchases by consumers. Even a celebrated recovery needed later operational correction. [13] [14]

The deeper lesson. Entertainment is particularly coherent when the audience can perform the activity it celebrates. A construction story can lead back to construction. But coherence does not remove costs or prove incrementality. For Blackwish, showing a genuine creative choice and its usable result is more defensible than borrowing the aura of a finished entertainment franchise. Participation should likewise have explicit gates: an invitation to suggest a feature is not a promise to build it, and enthusiastic response is not evidence that support or production capacity is unlimited.

3 Dove a position becomes a standard against which every execution is judged

Vehicle: a long-running brand position, commercial creative and separately assessable educational programs.

Dove was not a small soap brand suddenly created by a single purpose campaign. Unilever's history places its US beauty-bar launch in 1957, entry into 55 additional countries in 1991-94 and expansion into several product categories during 1995-2000. Real Beauty began in 2004; Men+Care and Baby Dove came later. International availability and product expansion therefore preceded and accompanied the famous positioning. A growth story that treats all of this as one film's effect gets the causal sequence wrong. [15]

Unilever reports €6 billion in Dove turnover for 2023. That is a company-reported measure of brand scale, not a standalone campaign profit statement. Its 2024 annual report also emphasizes innovation and premium products, including whole-body deodorants from Dove and Dove

Men+Care. A large enduring brand is an important outcome, but product development, price, retail availability and communication changed together. [16] [17]

The positioning offered something beyond cleansing: a different relationship to the conventions of beauty advertising. That can connect products through a recognizable idea of care. Yet a claim about people's confidence cannot be established by counting film views or product sales. The associated educational work is instructive precisely because some of it was examined separately.

A 2015 cluster randomized trial of a single-session school program found some immediate improvements that did not persist at follow-up. A later five-session trial in six British schools enrolled 1,495 pupils and found small body-esteem improvements through six months, without broad improvement across other outcomes. These are different interventions and bounded findings, not a contradiction to be resolved by choosing the more flattering one. [18] [19]

The later study's funding came from the Dove Self-Esteem Project, and a lead author disclosed consulting/advisory ties; authors retained final content authority. Funding is relevant context, not automatic refutation. This educational experiment does not validate every advertisement or show that buying Dove improves mental health. Program outcomes, representation, commercial performance and campaign causality remain different questions. [20]

The brand's own history supplies a warning about consistency. In October 2017 Dove removed a Facebook advertisement and apologized after criticism of a shirt-changing sequence that included a Black woman transitioning into a white woman. The clip then revealed another woman, so the Black-to-white transition was not its entire sequence. [21]

The subsequent model was Asian, and Lola Ogunyemi, the Black model, defended the inclusive concept. Her account is relevant context, not a reason to erase the criticism or apology. The episode establishes conflicting interpretations and a public response, not racist intent or a measured sales effect. [69]

The deeper lesson. A values-based position is not a decorative mission statement attached to ordinary production. It changes the standard against which casting, imagery, editing, partners and product experience are judged. The promise can survive an individual failure, but survival does not make the failure harmless. A creative project should choose commitments it can carry into routine decisions, not only a launch manifesto. Evidence of a useful educational component should be reported at that component's actual scale, without turning it into either a sales claim or a universal promise of personal transformation.

4 Spotify Wrapped the audience receives an object it may want to share

Vehicle: a product-integrated annual retrospective with voluntary social distribution.

Wrapped is more interesting than a campaign that persuaded people to repeat a slogan. It gives users a personal object: a way to remember listening, show taste or find common ground. The brand travels with something that may serve the user's own expressive purpose. The plausible mechanism combines relevant personal material, low-effort sharing and a synchronized annual occasion. None of those elements alone guarantees that an imitation will spread.

Spotify reported more than 225 million monthly active users engaging with Wrapped in 2023, and more than 245 million engaged users in 2024. These are campaign-specific company counts across

successive years, stronger evidence of recurring participation than a single celebrated launch. They are not a clean participation-rate trend without stable eligibility and engagement definitions. [22] [23]

The company also reported its first profitable full year in 2024. That financial milestone belongs to the whole business, not to Wrapped alone. The simultaneous facts cannot tell us what would have happened without the campaign, or how pricing, membership growth and cost changes contributed. A profitable company can run ineffective campaigns; an effective campaign can exist inside an unprofitable company. [24]

For 2025, management reported more than 300 million engaged users, over 630 million social shares and its highest single day of subscriber intake on launch day. It also acknowledged criticism of the previous year's edition. A share is not a distinct person reached, subscriber intake is not retained incremental profit, and a record audience does not refute dissatisfaction among some users. The public record supports scale and continuity, not a public causal return-on-investment estimate. [25]

The less visible story is production. Spotify's engineering account of the 2025 Wrapped Archive describes approximately 1.4 billion pregenerated reports for about 350 million eligible users, using a smaller production model, human and automated evaluation, and capacity prepared before launch. It describes grounding insights in listening records and screening outputs. These are company engineering disclosures, not independent reliability or safety certification. The apparent ease of the shareable object sits on substantial preparation. [26]

A recurring occasion creates a comparison with last year. AP reported that some users found the 2024 experience too minimal and missed earlier features. That establishes actual criticism, not population-wide rejection. [27]

Spotify told Axios that generative AI produced neither 2024 Wrapped's data results nor its creative design. [28]

The deeper lesson. Useful self-expression is different from extracting promotional labor. A recap can be enjoyed privately; sharing need not be the price of receiving it. But a personal object also promises recognition, making inaccurate interpretations unusually conspicuous. Blackwish could privately explore a useful finished artifact that its maker might choose to share. It should not infer that a public gallery, compulsory sharing, behavioral profiling or an annual event is therefore needed. A sharing button supplies distribution infrastructure, not a reason to care.

Part II How success can outgrow a promise

5 Hoover selling appliances created a travel obligation

Vehicle: a purchase-linked free-flight promotion, 1992-1995.

The offer connected an ordinary household purchase with a much more exciting reward. Contemporary reporting describes a promotion offering European flights starting in August 1992 and a later offer of flights to the US, with qualifying purchases bringing two return tickets. Customers bought inexpensive eligible appliances; a secondary market in vacuums appeared. By

March 1993 travel operators were struggling to supply seats, senior executives had departed and parent company Maytag had taken responsibility for fulfillment. These are contemporary reported developments, not an audited count of every claimant. [29]

The accounting made the exposure concrete. Maytag's 1993 Form 10-K recorded $60.4 million in pretax charges for additional costs of the two flight programs: $50 million as a special charge and $10.4 million in operating expense. It separately reported $12.2 million of related charges in 1992. Those figures are period-specific accounting charges, not a verified lifetime cash cost. The filing also identified other causes of European weakness, preventing a clean attribution of the entire business decline to the promotion. [30]

By April 1994 Hoover said 220,000 people had flown or been booked. A booking was progress toward delivery, not proof of completed travel. The distinction matters because repair is often reported in a unit that sounds more complete than it is. [31]

In 1995 Maytag sold its European operations for $164.3 million cash, subject to adjustment, and recorded a $140.8 million pretax disposal loss. It retained indemnity exposure for flight claims above the transferred reserve. The disposal loss was not the promotion's price tag, and the sale does not prove the offer alone forced the divestment. Obligations nevertheless outlived the initial burst of sales. [32]

The mechanism. The promotion sold two different things: an appliance available now and a travel entitlement dependent on seats, dates, bookings and other firms. Appliance revenue was not all available to pay for flights; only the relevant contribution could fund incremental obligations. A stronger reward could also attract buyers especially determined to redeem it. Buying the cheapest qualifying item and claiming the advertised benefit was compliant behavior, not abuse.

The sober counterfactual is not “make redemption difficult enough that the model works.” Before sale, an entitlement needs funding and deliverable capacity. After sale, changing future offers does not erase existing claims. A transparent queue or genuinely voluntary equivalent remedy may help, but the advertiser cannot retroactively convert an entitlement into a lottery merely because demand was enthusiastic.

6 Pepsi Number Fever the memorable number and the valid winner diverged

Vehicle: a bottle-cap prize promotion in the Philippines, 1992; litigation extending into 2007.

The Supreme Court's account describes a promotion originally scheduled from February to May 1992 and extended after its success. Caps carried a three-digit number, a security code and a prize amount. Pepsi announced 349 on 25 May for the next day; many holders brought in 349 caps with nonmatching codes. Pepsi said valid-code winners would receive full prizes and offered ₱500 for certain nonwinning caps. The Court ultimately treated the correct security code as essential and reversed the challenged award. [33]

A later decision recounts redemption queues, an initial replacement of 349 by 134, and subsequent publication of valid 349 security codes. It records roughly 486,170 holders accepting goodwill redemptions at an aggregate cost of about ₱240 million. The Court reversed damages under its earlier rulings on wrong-code caps. A company could therefore prevail on the legal entitlement question while still facing a large communication, claims and goodwill burden. [34]

Another decision explains that old nonwinning 349 caps remained in circulation when 349 was inadvertently chosen during the extended promotion with different codes. It recounts the finding that the code requirement was emphasized in promotional materials and that negligence had not been established. The case is not a judicial finding that every person holding 349 was owed the printed prize. Nor is it adequately described as a mysterious computer error with no operational history. [35]

The mechanism. The public-facing recognition cue was compact and memorable; full eligibility depended on additional information. Extending the promotion created a new interaction with old physical inventory already in shops and homes. The back office could know which codes were valid without the audience experiencing the result as intelligible or fair.

This is a versioning lesson as much as a promotion lesson. Old packaging, screenshots, download pages and instructions do not disappear when a new campaign begins. A revised promise must be reconciled with the objects people already possess. Legal defensibility and understandable communication are different achievements. Goodwill payments can acknowledge disruption without proving that every expectation was satisfied, and disappointment does not automatically create a legal entitlement. Both distinctions are necessary for a fair account.

7 MoviePass normal use became the behavior the company tried to prevent

Vehicle: the original low-price cinema subscription, 2017-2020; subsequent enforcement and criminal proceedings.

The FTC complaint describes an August 2017 offer of up to one new movie daily for $9.95 per month and approximately 3.2 million subscribers by early 2018. It alleges that frequent users were later targeted with password disruption, burdensome ticket verification and undisclosed spending limits, including restrictions affecting people who followed the rules. Those are allegations in a regulator's complaint, not findings after a contested trial. They describe a crucial inversion: advertised access became a cost the provider sought to suppress. [36]

The contemporary finances show why mere subscriber growth was not a complete success metric. HMNY's first-quarter 2018 filing reported approximately $49.44 million in total revenue against $135.97 million in consolidated cost of revenue, producing an $86.53 million gross loss before operating expenses. Subscription revenue was about $47.16 million. The balance sheet also carried roughly $84.89 million in deferred revenue: receipts associated with future service, not surplus profit. These are consolidated accounts, not precise per-subscriber cohort economics. [37]

The FTC's final 2021 consent order records Chapter 7 filings by the original MoviePass and HMNY in January 2020. Respondents neither admitted nor denied the complaint's allegations apart from jurisdictional matters; the order restricted misrepresentations and imposed security obligations. The legal disposition should not be rewritten as an admission of every alleged consumer practice. [38]

Separate criminal proceedings concerned investor fraud. DOJ's case record reports guilty pleas by J. Mitchell Lowe in September 2024 and Theodore Farnsworth in January 2025, and describes misleading sustainability and revenue claims alongside concealed access restrictions. Those pleas do not retroactively adjudicate every FTC allegation. This history concerns the original company and plan, not an unqualified judgment about the later relaunched service. [39]

The mechanism. A subscription can collect money before the service is consumed while incurring a new third-party cost at each legitimate use. More subscribers may increase cash and advertised scale while making the eventual service obligation worse. Future advertising income, data revenue or bargaining power cannot be counted as current contribution merely because a pitch deck describes them.

The warning sign is especially general: a usage metric improves financially because people cannot obtain the promised service. Lower redemption, fewer tickets or fewer support contacts can reflect obstruction rather than reduced need. Humane correction changes new offers openly, honors existing terms or offers informed voluntary alternatives with funded remedies. It does not reclassify ordinary use as misconduct to rescue the economics.

8 Fyre confidence in the image was not evidence of a ready event

Vehicle: luxury-event promotion and fundraising, 2016-2017; later fraud and insolvency proceedings.

A 2019 court opinion recounts promotion beginning in December 2016 of a luxury Bahamas festival, cancellation on its first morning and stranded guests. The opinion discusses allegations about facilities and prepaid wristbands, but it was a pleading-stage ruling that dismissed claims against particular defendants with an opportunity to seek amendment. It did not decide that every person appearing in the promotional story committed fraud or that Fyre Media had established liability on every allegation. [40]

The organizers' 29 April 2017 statement attributed the failure to transport congestion, insufficient tent capacity and safety concerns. It promised refunds and free VIP access to a 2018 festival. This is evidence of what they said and promised, not proof that their causal explanation was complete, refunds were paid or another event was viable. Repair language can be as ambitious - and as unsupported - as launch language. [41]

The funding story was not merely an optimistic forecast that turned out badly. The SEC complaint described nonexistent cancellation insurance, artist arrangements not actually reached and fabricated financial metrics used in fundraising; it also connected the festival with publicity for a booking platform. McFarland admitted the SEC allegations, while other settling defendants did not. The SEC's $27.4 million figure covered offerings involving several ventures, not only festival attendees' losses. [42] [43]

DOJ reported a six-year sentence in October 2018 after McFarland's guilty pleas concerning multiple schemes, including a separate later sham-ticket scheme. That sentence was not simply punishment for staging an unsuccessful event. A 2020 bankruptcy opinion directed default judgments of about $10.99 million jointly against McFarland and Fyre Media and another $3.42 million against Fyre Media for wrongful transfers. A judgment records a legal obligation; it does not prove money was collected and returned to guests. [44] [45]

The mechanism. An event's safe capacity is limited by the weakest essential system. Attractive accommodation cannot replace transport; an artist's image cannot replace a contract; available cash cannot replace construction time. Publicity can create a commitment to a date without creating the resources needed to meet it. Fraud also corrupts the evidence on which apparently careful decisions might otherwise rely.

For an event, the humane priority at a readiness failure is safe arrivals, departures and basic needs, not preserving the promotional narrative. A proposed future experience must be optional and independently deliverable. Customers should not have to make a second speculative commitment to receive a remedy for the first. The principle transfers to software without pretending that a broken export and a stranded traveler are equivalent harms.

9 Cyberpunk 2077 a large launch and a broken platform promise could coexist

Vehicle: a highly publicized software release, followed by product repair and redistribution; case window 2020-2024.

Four days after the 10 December 2020 release, CD PROJEKT management said it had underestimated problems on base last-generation consoles and had shown the game mainly on PCs. It described ignored signals that refinement needed more time and said console review copies arrived only a day before launch. Management attributed the situation to inadequate attention to those versions rather than unusual internal or external release pressure. These are contemporaneous admissions and explanations, not permission to invent motives. Evidence from the stronger configuration could not establish every buyer's experience. [46]

On 18 December the company formally disclosed Sony's removal of the game from PlayStation Store following refund discussions. Existing purchases remained usable, physical distribution continued and support was promised. The restriction was concrete, but not a universal ban. At the same time, the company estimated more than 13 million sell-through copies by 20 December, accounting for stated returns and directly received refund requests within the reporting window. That did not establish universal satisfaction or capture every later refund. Commercial scale and customer failure existed together. [47] [48]

On 13 January 2021 the company publicly committed to fixes, progress reporting and improvement across platforms. That announcement was a repair promise, not independent verification of success. A June regulatory filing then announced the digital edition's return to PlayStation Store on 21 June 2021. Reinstatement established restored distribution, not perfect quality on every device. [49] [50]

Recovery also changed scope. The company's support page says that after Patch 1.6 further new content and improvements would be exclusive to PC, PlayStation 5 and Xbox Series X|S, while technical support remained for older platforms. Later praise of newer editions cannot be silently transferred to the original hardware audience. A better future product may be genuinely valuable without fully delivering what an earlier customer expected on different equipment. [51]

The company's 2024 management report records the November announcement of more than 30 million base-game copies and over eight million expansion copies sold. These cumulative figures show later commercial durability. They do not isolate the contributions of technical repair, new hardware, price changes, expansion content, publicity or advertising. Nor do they retroactively restore time or trust lost during the original launch. The figures describe the stated historical window, not a claim to be the latest sales totals. [52]

The mechanism. A selected demonstration can be real and still be inadequate evidence for a broad offer. The failure lies in transferring proof across conditions: from one machine to another, an expert sequence to a novice workflow, or a single successful run to ordinary reliability.

Marketing and engineering can each describe a true local fact while the overall message implies more than either has established.

For Blackwish, a desktop preview is not Android validation; a generated result is not a save-and-reopen demonstration; a tiny phonetic prototype is not established reading instruction. The useful correction is precise evidence and platform scope, not a ban on ambition. A later improved edition also deserves an honest description of its merits without being used to erase the experience of an earlier cohort.

Part III Long term mechanisms and limits

Expectations accurate ambition is better than theatrical modesty

The familiar prescription to underpromise and overdeliver is too simple. A meta-analysis of 150 records, encompassing 58,597 participants, found a positive association between expectations and satisfaction. The experimental subgroup also showed a smaller positive association. Retrospective reports can mix earlier expectations with later experience, and the synthesis did not establish that deliberately overpromising is beneficial. It does undermine the claim that lower expectations are generally the route to happier customers. These populations and designs do not determine a creator-software project's satisfaction response. [53]

A laboratory study by Spreng and Dröge found that both understated and overstated attribute performance could reduce satisfaction with the marketer's information. Lowering expectations did not reliably improve satisfaction. Separately, Gneezy and Epley's promise studies found that breaking a promise attracted a negative response without a corresponding general premium for exceeding it. The latter concerns interpersonal evaluation, not an advertising demand curve. [54] [55]

The practical distinction is among **positive expectation**, **prediction** and **commitment**. “This is an enjoyable way to explore characters” expresses an intended experience that still needs honest support. “This build exported this example in these conditions” is a testable report. “Every device will work, and help will always be immediate” creates much broader commitments. The goal is not to make a good offering sound worse. It is to describe its genuine upside vividly while keeping the binding-sounding promise precise.

Quality signals confidence is not proof

Milgrom and Roberts modeled conditions under which costly advertising can signal hidden quality, with repeat purchases important to the incentive structure. That is a conditional theoretical explanation. Experiments by Kirmani and Wright found that cost cues could affect expected quality in some circumstances; expected quality was the outcome, not independently verified performance. Caves and Greene's analysis of roughly 200 product evaluations did not support advertising expenditure as a general quality signal, instead connecting positive associations mainly to verifiable attribute information. Theory, inference and product evidence should not be collapsed. [56] [57] [58]

A small project need not imitate the apparent expense of a large launch. It can make the proposition inspectable: a reproducible example, an ordinary workflow, visible prerequisites and a result the user can examine. Polish can help people understand. It becomes dangerous when polish carries the evidentiary weight that a working demonstration should carry instead.

Consistency preserve recognition without maximizing repetition

A meta-analysis of forced-exposure experiments found that recall and brand attitude responded differently to repetition. Its fitted exposure counts are not live-platform frequency prescriptions: spacing, attention, familiarity and outcome differ from ordinary media use. Separate field and laboratory work found that annoyance could fade faster than memory, with a later preference effect depending on category relevance. That does not establish that irritating an audience is profitable, kind or necessary. [59] [60]

System1 and the IPA's observational consistency research linked more than 4,000 ads across 56 brands and five years. More consistent brands were associated with stronger reported business effects, but selection and reverse causality remain possible: successful brands may find consistency easier, and weak performance may trigger changes. The study is not a randomized estimate of retaining a slogan or agency. [61]

The useful distinction is a stable identity with varied evidence, rather than a new identity every week or the same interruption forever. A recognizable name and visual system can accompany several accurate examples. A product can become easier to remember without multiplying the promises attached to it. Consistency means that the next communication belongs to the same understandable project, not that nobody is allowed to revise a mistaken claim.

Promotions a spike can change who arrives and when they buy

Anderson and Simester's randomized catalog studies followed later purchasing and found different outcomes for new and established customers. Deeper discounts could create genuine learning for new customers as well as shift timing or selection. Their comparisons among people who bought are not pure randomized comparisons of identical purchasers: the offer itself changes who enters that group. A conditional fall in repeat purchases cannot simply be labeled the total causal demand loss. [62]

Mela, Jedidi and Bowman's longitudinal scanner-panel analysis linked more promotion with less frequent purchasing but larger quantities when purchases occurred. That is observational evidence consistent with waiting and stockpiling, not proof that every discount permanently damages a brand. Stockpiling physical goods also does not transfer literally to a single software license. [63]

The question is not whether generosity is good or bad in the abstract. It is which constraint the offer removes, which audience it attracts, and what obligation follows. A useful free sample can reduce uncertainty; an extravagant reward can attract people primarily interested in the reward. Existing customers should not be blamed for responding rationally to public terms. Nor should a permanently free core be described as a temporary discount on revenue that has never existed.

Long term value neither delayed clicks nor an unlimited excuse

Lodish and colleagues followed 55 controlled television advertising-weight tests for established packaged goods, with two years after the initial test year. Later average effects were positive among tests with initial effects; tests without initial effects did not show a later average rescue. A subsequent update reused older long-run estimates rather than adding new long-run experiments, and its “productive” grouping used a lenient significance threshold. The work supports the possibility of carryover, not a universal multiplier or a guarantee that disappointing results will eventually turn around. [64] [65]

McCain offers a concrete, but differently evidenced, story. The IPA's account of its 2015-2023 strategy describes a move away from escalating promotions toward a sustained family-teatime platform. It reports a 47% reduction in price elasticity, a 37% improvement in consideration and a modeled additional 5% sales volume. A later methodological explanation describes a custom ten-year model and an estimated price effect much larger than the volume effect. This is a company/agency award case with econometric attribution, not random assignment; product, competition, inflation and distribution remain relevant. [66] [67]

The attractive mechanism is that people may become less inclined to treat a product as interchangeable, preserving pricing power rather than merely moving more units this week. But no allocation rule follows automatically. The IPA's own contextual analysis behind the familiar 60:40 discussion used 615 selected for-profit award submissions and says the appropriate balance varies. It did not randomly assign businesses to budget ratios. A free preview with limited support capacity need not have the same bottleneck as an established food brand. [68]

Synthesis. Good promotion can create a useful service, a remembered possibility, a coherent expectation or an occasion for expression. It can also create a costly entitlement, a concentrated queue or a recurring obligation. Long-term thinking means recognizing both sides of that accumulation. It does not mean attributing all later success to advertising, or postponing a verdict on poor economics indefinitely.

Part IV Grandfathering without erasing commitments

Preserve the benefit without exempting the method from review

Grandfathering can refer to several different things: keeping a price or access entitlement, retaining an old implementation, preserving data and compatibility, or qualifying for a specific legal exemption. These are not interchangeable. A safer implementation may preserve an old benefit; an old workflow may fail current review without making earlier legitimate participation wrongful. Different cohorts can also reasonably receive different terms because they relied on different offers.

The essential distinction is **entitlement preservation versus process immunity**. Reviewing how a promise is fulfilled is not, by itself, authority to withdraw the promise. Conversely, honoring a commitment does not require leaving every old technical or organizational method untouched forever. The object, cohort, duration and conditions must be named rather than hidden inside the word “legacy.”

Netflix shows why expiry and perceived continuity differ

Netflix's 2014 Form 10-K described the US two-screen HD plan as $8.99 for newer members, while existing members could retain $7.99 for two years if they remained members. This was a bounded price-and-membership protection, not a universal lifetime-price promise. [70]

Its July 2016 shareholder letter reported 1.7 million global net additions against a 2.5 million forecast. Management associated unexpectedly higher churn with coverage of the protection's expiry, suggesting some subscribers understood it as a new increase. It separately said churn among members actually moved off protected pricing was modest and expected. That is management's observation and explanation, not independent causal identification. [71]

The distinction. Honoring a stated duration does not guarantee that people remember its end. A transition should make the original benefit, remaining term, successor price and available choices intelligible together. Yet backlash alone does not establish a broken promise. Contractual fulfillment, perceived continuity and commercial performance are different evaluations.

Google separates eligibility from the machinery of delivery

Google's June 2022 webinar recap said individuals and families using accounts non-commercially could retain G Suite legacy free edition by opting out of the Workspace transition through a super-administrator account. The stated protection concerned a defined cohort; it was not a promise that all legacy subscriptions would keep every arrangement. [72]

Google's help guidance, updated in October 2026, describes reviews of personal-use eligibility, appeals for misclassification and export options. It also says personal free accounts began moving from per-user to pooled storage in May 2025 without reducing total storage; previously purchased legacy add-on storage remains usable. Free editions do not include support. These are Google's stated arrangements, not proof that every review or transition works correctly. [73]

The distinction. Checking eligibility is different from abolishing a benefit. Preserving total capacity is also different from preserving each person's control over that capacity. A transition can conserve a headline quantity while changing permissions, usability or dependence on an administrator. Those differences need to be evaluated rather than dismissed as invisible implementation details.

Sonos separates working devices from a working integrated system

In January 2020 Sonos's CEO apologized for its legacy-product announcement, said devices would keep working after new feature updates ended, and pledged fixes and security patches for as long as possible. He described separating legacy and modern systems and said upgrades should be motivated by attractive new products rather than feeling forced. The maintenance assurance was qualified, not perpetual feature parity. [74]

Sonos's support documentation explains the boundary: separate S1 and S2 systems require separate apps and their products cannot be grouped together. Some single-stream services also restrict simultaneous playback across both systems on the same account. [75]

The distinction. “Each device still works” does not establish that the customer's existing integrated arrangement still works. Compatibility can be part of the promised benefit, not merely a provider's choice of internal architecture. A legacy branch may preserve useful operation while introducing important limits. Neither its continued existence nor its newer counterpart should be described as complete continuity without examining the whole workflow.

A commitment record is more precise than a legacy label

For a proposed transition, record these features before deciding what stays or changes:

- **Protected object and cohort:** price, access, support, output, data-use restriction or interoperability; qualifying person, account, device, version and enrollment date.
- **Duration and continuity:** actual expiry, renewal conditions, and effects of cancellation, transfer, replacement or optional upgrade. Do not invent a forfeiture condition after reliance.
- **Admission and expansion:** whether new users, seats or devices qualify. Closing new admissions can contain growth without ending existing maintenance obligations.
- **Review triggers and authority:** risk, dependency loss, legal change or material version change. A review date is a decision point, not an automatic termination clause.
- **Transition evidence and remedy:** preserved original terms, a specific loss comparison, usable export, notice, appeal and any appropriate replacement, credit or refund. These remedies are not automatically interchangeable.

Sunk investment matters as evidence of reliance and migration burden, not as authority to continue an identified hazard. Where a method is unsafe, first ask whether a safer implementation can preserve the benefit. If not, explain the actual limitation and proportionate alternatives. Rollback is an option only when safe and authorized; it must not reactivate a known hazard. Nor should “security” become an unsupported label for unrelated monetization.

Notice consent and legal duty are different

FTC guidance issued in February 2024 warns that quietly adopting more permissive data practices through retroactive terms or privacy-policy amendments may be unfair or deceptive, including expanded sharing or AI-training uses. A new policy label does not automatically release data collected under earlier promises. This is official US issue-spotting, not a worldwide rule for every software or price change. [76]

An earlier enforcement example makes the distinction concrete. In Gateway Learning, the FTC alleged deceptive privacy promises and unfair retroactive changes after customer information was rented. The settlement described by the agency required affirmative opt-in before sharing information collected under the previous policy and barred retroactive material changes without consent. The case does not establish that every unrelated product modification needs that same remedy. [77]

Notice communicates a change; valid consent can authorize something where consent is relevant; a legal duty may remain regardless of either. Actual obligations depend on the promise, jurisdiction, sector and data involved. This is research, not personalized legal advice.

For Blackwish, an instruction to re-examine old methods should be kept distinct from authority to withdraw existing commitments, discard data-use promises or label earlier legitimate acts wrongful solely because a later process changed. This is an analytical boundary, not replacement doctrine. Preserve the original evidence, review the method, and identify exactly what a successor keeps or removes. Any live transition still needs explicit manual ratification.

Part V A private expectation system for Blackwish

Start with the version people can actually receive

The supplied project baseline is the main generator **PREVIEW v7.1**, with separate tiny exploratory phonetic-print work. The project is intended to be free, offline-first and G-rated. Those descriptions are not new independent findings from this research. G-rated here is an intended content boundary, not an official rating or a guarantee of universal child suitability. Desktop synthetic checks do not establish Android operation, learning transfer or complete accessibility.

A useful hypothetical trajectory is modest in scope but not timid in value: show one complete, genuinely supported creative workflow; provide the same explanation in readable text; let the resulting sample be useful without signup or sharing; and keep a precise versioned reference nearby. An engaging fictional scene may express the project's tone, but it should not imply a finished animated series or capabilities the tool does not contain.

The sample should answer the natural questions raised by the promise: What does the person choose? What does the tool supply? Which details remain under the person's control? What survives saving and reopening? What can be exported? What requires setup or connectivity? An unsupported answer remains an explicit unknown, not a blank to fill with persuasive copy.

An operational expectations ledger

The following is a private planning structure, not approved public wording or an implemented process. Each entry would carry an accountable owner, evidence date, build identifier, review state and links to preserved evidence. Unassigned ownership stays visibly unassigned. A reviewer should be able to distinguish a demonstrated fact, an intended experience and a future commitment without decoding project lore.

Candidate proposition	Evidence and boundary needed	Dependency or failure response
A person can complete a character workflow	Named build, ordinary start-to-finish sequence, human choices and actual result	Correct or withdraw the affected description if the ordinary path fails; do not substitute a selected highlight
Work can be kept and reused	Separate evidence for session state, saving, reopening and each export format	Preserve originals; state format and version limits; provide a verified workaround if one exists
The core works offline	Installation, first-run and later-use conditions checked separately	Describe residual network dependencies; do not infer privacy or universal compatibility from “offline”

Candidate proposition	Evidence and boundary needed	Dependency or failure response
Access is free	What is included, actual terms and any optional complements clearly separated	No invented revenue per download; future paid offers cannot silently redefine the current promise
A particular device is supported	Evidence for that device, browser, operating system and delivery path	Unsupported platforms remain unverified, not presumptively supported
A component is educational	Identify the actual exercise and evidence, distinguishing exploration from validated instruction	Remove unsupported learning claims; keep the phonetic prototype separate from the main builder
Help is available	Defined channel, capacity, scope and response expectations	Do not advertise immediate or perpetual personal service without a funded ability to provide it
Outputs may be shared	Relevant export behavior, rights information and voluntary choice	No forced gallery, advertising identifier, hidden prompt upload or compulsory sharing
A legacy benefit continues	Original offer, protected cohort, duration and workflow comparison	Review the method without inventing forfeiture; preserve data promises and make losses and remedies explicit

The ledger records unsupported interpretations as well as literal wording. “Offline” may be heard as “no installation dependencies”; “free” as “no time or data cost”; “educational” as “proven to improve reading.” A short sentence can create a broad impression even when its author intended a narrower one. The repair is to clarify the material boundary near the benefit, not hide it in a remote disclaimer.

There is also a capacity side. In a purely invented example, 1,000 additional installations with a 5% support-contact rate create 50 requests. At 20 minutes each, that is about 16.7 hours of work. If only five hours are available, roughly 11.7 hours of backlog are added before existing work. These are arithmetic assumptions, not Blackwish measurements or a proposal to run an audience experiment. They demonstrate why negligible download cost does not imply negligible fulfillment cost.

Humane recovery when expectations are already wrong

Recovery should restore informed choice rather than defend the campaign's preferred story. A workable private specification would separate five tasks:

1. **Protect the person's immediate situation.** Preserve their work and explain what remains usable. For a software problem, avoid a “fix” that risks the only copy of a project. For a service failure, attend to the actual unmet need rather than a vanity metric.

2. **State the mismatch precisely.** Name the affected version, platform or promise; say what is known and unknown. Do not imply every person is affected when the scope is narrower, or dismiss a real failure because others succeeded.
3. **Prevent new reliance on the same error.** Prepare a correction or withdrawal of the inaccurate future claim. Any live publication or revision still requires the user's explicit manual ratification. Preserve the earlier claim and date so the history is not silently rewritten.
4. **Offer a remedy that exists.** Distinguish delivered fixes, verified workarounds, funded refunds where applicable and estimates of future work. A future edition is an option, not automatic compensation. Someone should not have to waive a legitimate remedy to support the creator's recovery narrative.
5. **Close the obligation with evidence.** Record whether the person received the promised result or chosen remedy, not merely whether an apology was sent or a ticket closed. Collect no additional personal data without a real need and appropriate authorization.

The tone should be factual and respectful. No compulsory mantras, fear-based dependence, confirm-shaming or hidden instruction belongs in the recovery path. Holy Fear should not be used to create insecurity or imply threats. A person who reasonably decides the tool is not for them has not failed the project. A completed one-time task can be enough.

Part VI Three distinct Zen text review rounds

These rounds use POINT, BRIDGE, PATH and SHADOW as an **operational interpretation for reviewing this manuscript**, not a new statement of Blackwish canon. They examine reasoning and hypothetical text. They are not empirical tests, legal clearance, independent audit, safety certification, manual ratification or deployment authority.

Round one evidence and causal restraint

POINT: Explain what the cases actually establish. Durable business performance, useful-program outcomes and campaign participation are distinct results.

BRIDGE: Tie factual claims to their proper records. Corporate financial statements support company results; a regulator's complaint remains allegations; a later guilty plea has its own scope. An award model does not become a randomized experiment.

PATH: The manuscript separates platform-specific launch evidence, period-specific accounting charges and dated company counts. It removes the tempting claim that a movie, purpose film or annual recap single-handedly produced the company's success. Legacy-plan announcements are treated as specific company arrangements, not universal entitlements.

SHADOW: Selected survivors hide failed imitators; retrospective explanations encourage causal confidence. The remaining uncertainty is explicit rather than resolved by a confident narrative. This pass narrows what can be learned without reducing every case to “nothing is knowable.”

Round two agency interpretation and humane treatment

POINT: Preserve the audience's ability to understand, use, decline or seek a remedy without manipulation.

BRIDGE: Compare the attractive headline with the actual entitlement and the likely interpretation. A complete useful sample differs from a compulsory promotional task; ordinary redemption differs from abuse.

PATH: The manuscript rejects deliberately lowering expectations as a universal tactic, keeps the continued Dove sequence in context, distinguishes goodwill from legal entitlement, and makes future repairs optional rather than imposed replacements for existing obligations. Legacy transitions distinguish notice from consent and baseline operation from the whole prior workflow.

SHADOW: Disclosure can be technically present but practically remote; criticism can be oversimplified; a sympathetic recovery story can erase the earlier cohort. The correction is intelligible terms and specific treatment of affected people, not ceremonial language about trust.

Round three delivery renewal and authorization

POINT: Make a proposed promise deliverable over its stated scope and horizon, including success conditions and adverse conditions.

BRIDGE: Connect each claim to build evidence, capacity, ownership and actual resources. Attention does not supply airline seats, support hours, reliable exports or funded refunds.

PATH: The expectation ledger separates current facts, exploratory work, future commitments and protected legacy benefits. A method review does not itself cancel an entitlement. The recovery sequence preserves originals and requires evidence of delivered remedies. A versioned reference and an explicit unresolved dependency replace blanket compatibility and perpetual-support language.

SHADOW: A popular launch can create concentrated demand; a recurring ritual can become an unfunded annual obligation; a repair can multiply promises. This pass keeps public changes, spending, tracking, human experiments and deployment behind explicit authorization and manual ratification. Textual coherence is not product readiness.

Part VII Bounded Death Knell the strongest counterexamples

Here Death Knell is a finite adversarial text review: try to break each material principle with a plausible counterexample, then keep only the narrower claim that survives. It is not a guarantee that no unseen failure exists.

Useful content can still be wasted effort. A beautifully made guide may have no distribution, no distinctive advantage or no relevant connection to the product. The surviving principle is to create a genuinely useful complementary object with an accountable maintenance scope - not to become a publisher by default.

A truthful promise can fail unexpectedly. Evidence cannot cover every device and circumstance. The surviving principle is proportionate verification, visible scope and a humane response to exceptions, not an impossible promise of error-free delivery.

A high expectation can improve experience. Accurate confidence may help people notice real value. The surviving principle is calibrated ambition and precise commitments, not low expectations for their own sake or permission to deceive for a hoped-for psychological benefit.

A promotion can produce real new demand. Not every sale borrows from the future, and not every low-price user is unprofitable. The surviving principle is to distinguish learning, timing, selection and fulfillment economics rather than condemn generosity.

A later successful product can be genuinely excellent. Recovery need not be dismissed as spin. The surviving principle is cohort and platform specificity: recognize the later achievement without treating it as proof that the earlier promise was kept.

A lawful outcome can still leave people worse off; a complaint need not prove illegality. Legal, operational and human judgments are related but not interchangeable. The surviving principle is accurate entitlement language and practical remedy, without inventing either liability or exoneration.

Consistency can preserve a mistake. A stable brand system is useful only if inaccurate claims can be corrected. The surviving principle is continuity of identity and purpose with willingness to revise unsupported execution.

A legacy process can become unsafe. Preserving reliance does not require freezing hazardous machinery; reviewing the machinery does not erase the original commitment. The surviving principle is benefit-preserving adaptation where feasible, with specific evidence, authority and remedies where continuity is impossible.

Better measurement can cost more than it contributes. A richer dashboard can require unjustified data collection and still fail to identify causality. The surviving principle is to seek decision-relevant evidence with minimal burden; the presence of a ledger does not authorize telemetry or experiments.

The review stops here because the identified counterexamples yield distinct, actionable boundaries rather than another layer of reassurance. Reopen the affected section when the claim, build, audience, evidence, law or distribution changes materially. Repeating the same analysis is not a substitute for a new fact.

Closing judgment

The strongest advertising stories are not stories in which communication replaces delivery. They are stories in which the communication gives people access to something worth wanting: useful information, constructive participation, respectful representation, recognizable expression or an actual product advantage.

The most consequential failures also do not always begin with an unpopular advertisement. Some begin with overwhelming demand. They become dangerous when the organization treats ordinary

reliance on its promise as an obstacle, mistakes receipts for resources available after fulfillment, or uses another promise to postpone the first obligation.

For Blackwish, the warranted direction remains private preparation around a demonstrable, useful creative experience and an honest explanation of its limits. Ambition can be expressed fully without making unearned claims. A sustainable promise is neither the smallest possible promise nor the loudest one: it is a valuable proposition whose evidence, capacity, terms and recovery path remain visible. This casebook authorizes no campaign, publication, experiment or deployment.

Source ledger

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